

D839

Teaching Writing in Secondary Schools

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

While drafting an argument essay in a classroom that has new standing desks, a student realizes her research is thin and goes back to find two more sources before continuing. Her essay is due in a week. How should the teacher view this?

- A. As a time-management problem, since the essay is due in a week.
- B. As a healthy recursive move in the writing process.
- C. As an error, because research must be completed before drafting begins.
- D. As editing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which classroom practice best reflects a recursive view of the writing process?

- A. Letting students return to planning or drafting after conferences, as the piece requires.
- B. Teaching editing before drafting.
- C. Grading only the final draft.
- D. Requiring every student to finish each stage on the same day before moving to the next.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A teacher who has taught for twelve years asks students to revise their narratives. One student, who types very quickly, fixes three spelling errors and adds commas, then says he is done. What should the teacher tell him?

- A. Those changes are editing; revision means rethinking ideas, organization, or details, such as adding dialogue to show a key moment.
- B. Type more words since he is fast.
- C. Revision and editing are the same thing.
- D. Great, his revision is complete.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student moves her strongest paragraph to the beginning and cuts an off-topic section. What has she done?

- A.** Published.
- B.** Edited.
- C.** Revised.
- D.** Prewritten.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

An eighth-grade teacher, whose room has a class pet turtle, is starting a unit on writing op-eds for the first time. None of her students has read an op-ed. The unit will end with a school newspaper feature. What should she do first?

- A.** Have students start drafting an op-ed right away.
- B.** Have students write about the class turtle.
- C.** Assign a five-paragraph essay instead.
- D.** Have students read and analyze several op-eds to notice how writers make and support claims.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A teacher who recently attended a summer workshop introduces a planning strategy for persuasive essays. She names the strategy, models it with a think-aloud, has students memorize its steps, supports them as they practice, and teaches them to set goals and self-check. Her school recently moved to a new building. Which approach is she using?

- A.** Grammar drill.
- B.** Discovery learning.
- C.** Self-Regulated Strategy Development.
- D.** Writer's workshop with free choice only.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A tenth-grade teacher who teaches five sections returns an essay covered with red marks on every sentence, from commas to argument structure. The student, a strong athlete, looks overwhelmed. The goal of the unit was using evidence. What would be more effective?

- A. Mark even more errors so the student sees everything.
- B. Give only a letter grade.
- C. Comment on one or two priorities tied to using evidence, with a clear next step.
- D. Encourage the student to focus on sports.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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8.

In an argument essay, a student in a class that meets in the library writes: Schools should start later. A study found teens who slept more had better grades. The paragraph ends there. The student used a blue pen. What is missing?

- A. More evidence.
- B. A different pen color.
- C. A claim.
- D. A warrant explaining how later start times would lead to more sleep and better grades.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student's paragraph includes a claim, evidence, and a warrant. To strengthen it against opposing views, what should be added next?

- A. A counterclaim and rebuttal.
- B. A restatement of the claim.
- C. A personal story instead of evidence.
- D. A second claim unrelated to the first.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
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10.

Students who just finished a successful fundraiser write a report on it for the school principal. The teacher then asks them to write about the same event for fifth graders. The fundraiser raised \$2,400. What should change most?

- A.** Only the title.
- B.** The amount raised, to make it easier to understand.
- C.** Nothing; the facts are the same.
- D.** Tone, vocabulary, and details, to suit younger readers.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A piece of writing uses formal language, cites budget figures, and ends with a specific request for funding. For which audience and purpose was it most likely written?

- A.** Any audience, since good writing is the same for everyone.
- B.** A school board, to persuade it to approve money.
- C.** Classmates, to entertain them.
- D.** A personal journal, to reflect.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A student making a digital presentation on local water quality, with a clever title, adds spinning animations and music to every slide but includes no data or photos of the river. The presentation is 12 slides long. What feedback is best?

- A.** Shorten it to 5 slides.
- B.** Choose media that support the message, such as a data chart and river photos, and remove decorative effects.
- C.** Remove all visuals and use only text.
- D.** Add even more animations.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

While drafting an argument essay ~~in a classroom that has new standing desks~~, a student realizes her research is thin and goes back to find two more sources before continuing. ~~Her essay is due in a week.~~ How should the teacher view this?

Target word: view of a return to prewriting **Decides:** Moving back to research mid-draft is recursive.

A	Camouflage	The deadline does not decide the process question.
B	Correct	Writers return to earlier stages as needed.
C	Absolute language	The process is not a fixed line.
D	Confusion set	Editing fixes conventions, not research.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Which classroom practice best reflects a recursive view of the writing process?

Target word: choose the practice **Decides:** Students can move among stages as needed.

A	Correct	Allows movement back and forth.
B	Adjacent category	Changes the order but is still linear.
C	Dropped element	Ignores the process entirely.
D	Inverted operation	Enforces a linear sequence.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A teacher ~~who has taught for twelve years~~ asks students to revise their narratives. One student, ~~who types very quickly~~, fixes three spelling errors and adds commas, then says he is done. What should the teacher tell him?

Target word: revision vs. editing **Decides:** He edited conventions but did not revise content.

A	Correct	Revision changes content and structure.
B	Camouflage	Typing speed is irrelevant.
C	Absolute language	They are different stages.
D	Confusion set	Treats editing as revision.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

A student moves her strongest paragraph to the beginning and cuts an off-topic section. What has she done?

Target word: reverse: name the change **Decides:** Organization and content changed.

A	Adjacent category	Publishing shares the finished piece.
B	Inverted operation	Editing would fix spelling or punctuation.
C	Correct	Reorganizing and cutting content is revision.
D	Confusion set	Prewriting comes before a draft exists.

5. Answer D Concept 3

An eighth-grade teacher, ~~whose room has a class pet turtle~~, is starting a unit on writing op-eds for the first time. None of her students has read an op-ed. ~~The unit will end with a school newspaper feature.~~ What should she do first?

Target word: first step in a new genre **Decides:** Students have never seen the genre.

A	Dropped element	Skips seeing the genre.
B	Camouflage	The pet is irrelevant.
C	Adjacent category	A different, generic form.
D	Correct	Mentor texts show the genre's moves.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A teacher ~~who recently attended a summer workshop~~ introduces a planning strategy for persuasive essays. She names the strategy, models it with a think-aloud, has students memorize its steps, supports them as they practice, and teaches them to set goals and self-check. ~~Her school recently moved to a new building.~~ Which approach is she using?

Target word: name the approach **Decides:** Staged strategy instruction with self-regulation.

A	Confusion set	Focuses on conventions, not planning strategies.
B	Inverted operation	SRSD is explicit, not discovery-based.
C	Correct	Explicit stages plus goal-setting and self-monitoring.
D	Adjacent category	Lacks explicit staged strategy teaching.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A tenth-grade teacher ~~who teaches five sections~~ returns an essay covered with red marks on every sentence, from commas to argument structure. The student, ~~a strong athlete~~, looks overwhelmed. The goal of the unit was using evidence. What would be more effective?

Target word: better feedback **Decides:** Too many marks; the goal was evidence.

A	Inverted operation	Adds to overload.
B	Dropped element	Removes useful guidance.
C	Correct	Focused, actionable feedback tied to the goal.
D	Camouflage	Athletics are irrelevant.

8. Answer D Concept 6

In an argument essay, a student ~~in a class that meets in the library~~ writes: Schools should start later. A study found teens who slept more had better grades. The paragraph ends there. ~~The student used a blue pen.~~ What is missing?

Target word: missing element **Decides:** No explanation of why the evidence supports the claim.

A	Adjacent category	Evidence is present; the link is missing.
B	Camouflage	Irrelevant.
C	Dropped element	The claim is present.
D	Correct	The warrant links evidence to claim.

9. Answer A Concept 6 • transfer

A student's paragraph includes a claim, evidence, and a warrant. To strengthen it against opposing views, what should be added next?

Target word: next Toulmin element **Decides:** Address the opposing side.

A	Correct	Acknowledges and answers the opposing view.
B	Dropped element	Adds nothing new.
C	Inverted operation	Weakens the argument.
D	Adjacent category	Does not address opposition.

10. Answer D Concept 7

Students who just finished a successful fundraiser write a report on it for the school principal. The teacher then asks them to write about the same event for fifth graders. ~~The fundraiser raised \$2,400.~~ What should change most?

Target word: adjust for audience **Decides:** The audience changed.

A	Dropped element	Too small a change for a new audience.
B	Camouflage	Facts should stay accurate.
C	Absolute language	Audience changes how facts are presented.
D	Correct	The rhetorical situation shapes these choices.

11. Answer B Concept 7 • transfer

A piece of writing uses formal language, cites budget figures, and ends with a specific request for funding. For which audience and purpose was it most likely written?

Target word: reverse: infer the situation from the writing **Decides:** Formal tone, figures, and a funding request point to decision-makers.

A	Absolute language	Audience shapes the choices.
B	Correct	The choices fit a formal, persuasive request to decision-makers.
C	Inverted operation	Entertainment for peers would use a casual tone.
D	Adjacent category	A journal has no outside audience to persuade.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A student making a digital presentation on local water quality, ~~with a clever title,~~ adds spinning animations and music to every slide but includes no data or photos of the river. ~~The presentation is 12 slides long.~~ What feedback is best?

Target word: mode choice **Decides:** Media are decorative, not purposeful.

A	Camouflage	Length is not the issue.
B	Correct	Mode should serve audience and purpose.
C	Absolute language	Visuals can serve the purpose.
D	Inverted operation	Adds decoration.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The writing process is recursive	Writers move back and forth among planning, drafting, revising, and editing as needed; the stages are not a one-way line.	Treating the process as fixed steps done once in order.	A writer returns to an earlier stage.
2	Revision vs. editing	Revision changes content, organization, and ideas; editing fixes conventions such as spelling, grammar, and punctuation.	Calling a spelling and comma check revision.	The change is to ideas or structure vs. to surface correctness.
3	Mentor texts	Students study published or model texts to notice a genre's moves before writing their own.	Asking students to write in a genre they have never seen modeled.	A new genre and a planning choice.
4	Self-Regulated Strategy Development	SRSD teaches a writing strategy explicitly: build background, discuss, model, memorize, support, then independent use, with self-regulation such as goal-setting.	Telling students the strategy and expecting independent use right away.	A strategy taught in stages with modeling and self-monitoring.
5	Focused feedback	Effective writing feedback targets a few high-priority issues tied to the goal, so students can act on it.	Marking every error on the page.	A paper covered in red marks.
6	Toulmin argument	An argument has a claim, evidence (grounds), and a warrant that explains why the evidence supports the claim, plus counterclaims and rebuttals.	Assuming evidence speaks for itself without a warrant.	Evidence is listed with no explanation of how it supports the claim.
7	The rhetorical situation	Audience, purpose, and context determine genre, tone, and content choices.	Writing the same way for every audience.	The same content must be written for a different reader or purpose.
8	Choosing the mode for the purpose	In multimodal composition, students choose text, image, audio, or video because the mode serves the audience and purpose.	Adding media for decoration rather than meaning.	A digital project where media choices can be judged.

Course scope (public description): Teaching Writing in Secondary Schools is the second of three English discipline methods courses in the standard path. This course focuses on developing writing skills in adolescent learners and includes consideration of writing across a range of real-world contexts and genres, the writing process, and assessment of writing skills. Connections to the science of learning and the science of reading are spiraled throughout the content. Considerations of technology integration and different media modalities are included. This course will be assessed via one integrated PA task for the undergraduate version, with one additional PA task for the graduate version. The assessment will require candidates to demonstrate instructional skills. This methods course will count towards 7 hours of the 51 total clinical hours that learners will gain from their SCED methods courses.